Israel, on the other hand, is an explicitly ethno-nationalist state. It cannot be otherwise, or Zionism would lose its final vestiges of meaning.

The rest

In the autumn of 2016, as Netanyahu was plotting to kill the new public broadcaster, one of his cabinet ministers made an unflattering but telling comparison. “We have to put a stop to this Erdoganism,” the minister said. “We have to show him he can’t have everything he wants.”[2]

Despite its cultural affinity for the West, Israel in many ways bears a growing resemblance to two states on the eastern fringes of Europe—Turkey and Russia. Both have a long history, yet their modern incarnations, like Israel’s, are recent creations assembled from the ashes of empire by strong leaders: Ataturk, after the fall of the Ottomans; and Vladimir Putin, after the Soviet Union’s collapse and the chaos of the Yeltsin years.

For decades, all three countries suppressed elements of their identity. In Russia there was Communism, which tried to supersede both religion and the palette of ethnicities that made up the Soviet Union. Ataturk banned the *hijab* in public institutions, shuttered religious schools and instituted a new system of laws based on European civil codes. “I have no religion, and at times I wish all religions at the bottom of the sea,” he once said. “My people are going to learn the principles of democracy, the dictates of truth and the teachings of science.” He viewed most of his subjects as uncivilized, not unlike Ben Gurion’s assertion that the *mizrahim* lacked any “Jewish and human education.” Erdogan’s Justice and Development Party (AKP, in Turkish) rose to power for the same reasons as Begin’s Likud. It offered a more conservative and traditional majority the chance to end decades of dispossession at the hands of a secular, “European” elite.

The AKP, of course, had to overcome the army, which served as the guardian of Ataturk’s order. It carried out three military coups, plus the 1997 “postmodern coup”, over the past century. Israel has maintained civilian rule for seventy years (no small wonder, given how few of its citizens can trace their roots back to democratic countries). Yet in its own way, the Israeli army too has emerged as the last guardian of democratic values. Days after Ya’alon was sacked, one of Israel’s top security correspondents wrote, “In some conversations I’ve had recently with high-ranking officers about Mr. Lieberman’s appointment as defense minister,